One Drug, Many Prices:
A Proposal to Reform US Healthcare Pricing

Introduction

This paper proposes three structural reforms to pharmaceutical pricing and healthcare payment: consolidated government negotiation, Bloc-wide pricing as a condition of market access, and a central price lookup system. It is an intellectual exercise in policy design, addressed to academics and policy makers. Its purpose is to present an idea for consideration, clarify its logic, and invite critique and refinement. It leaves to others the work of political strategy, legislative drafting, and advocacy.

The US healthcare pricing system is broken, and the evidence is overwhelming. I present three interconnected reforms that combine to offer a comprehensive solution based on existing tools. I describe multiple cases in which some variant of the reforms has been implemented in the US healthcare system with strong results.

The problem

A colonoscopy costs $880 at the VA, $1,760 under Medicare, $5,816 under a commercial insurer, and $19,206 for uninsured patients. A chest X-ray costs $20 under Medicare, $60 under a private insurer, and $283 to the uninsured. These are not anomalies. Figure 1 shows the same pattern across ten commonly used drugs, hospital services, and outpatient procedures. In every case, the price of the same product or service swings several-fold across payers.

Uninsured patients are a vulnerable group who often face the highest prices. They pay the chargemaster prices in hospitals, fill prescriptions at undiscounted rates, and are billed whatever a physician's office chooses to post. These are not negotiated rates. They are sticker prices set unilaterally by the provider, and they are what patients without coverage actually get billed.

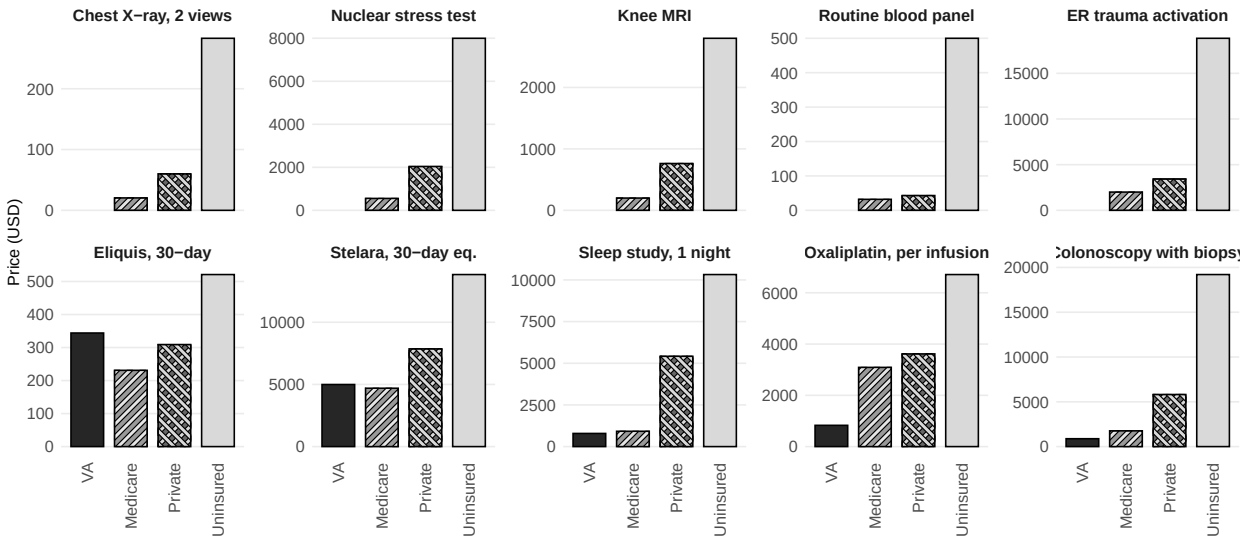

Figure 1: Price gaps across payers for the same service or product.

Notes: Bars show the total price each payer faces for the same service. Fill encodes the payer: solid dark is the VA, diagonal stripes is Medicare, crosshatch is a private insurer (total negotiated rate, including patient cost-sharing), and solid light gray is the uninsured (chargemaster or list price). Each panel uses its own vertical scale because the absolute amounts differ widely across services. Only services with at least three of the four payers are shown. Missing bars indicate no reliable figure was available in the cited sources. Full sources and derivations for each number are available on the companion site.

These price gaps are not limited to differences across payers within the United States. They extend to differences between the United States and every other developed country. Figure 2 compares US drug prices with prices in six other developed countries for nine widely used medications, all among the first ten drugs selected for Medicare negotiation under the Inflation Reduction Act. These drugs were chosen by CMS based on Medicare spending, not by the author. Every other country shown negotiates drug prices through centralized purchasing. The United States, until the Inflation Reduction Act, did not. The pattern is the same in every panel: the US list price (dark red) towers over what other nations pay (gray). Even after accounting for rebates and discounts that reduce the effective US price (orange), Americans still pay multiples of what patients in peer countries pay for identical drugs made by the same manufacturers. Where Medicare was authorized to negotiate (green), prices fell, but even the negotiated prices remain above what most other countries pay.

These price gaps persist because no one can see them. Obtaining the price of a surgery, a doctor's visit, or a prescription before receiving it is so difficult, cumbersome, and time-consuming that most Americans never try. The transaction cost of comparison shopping is high enough to eliminate comparison shopping entirely. Insurers without Medicare's bargaining power are pressured into paying whatever providers demand, and the uninsured pay the most of all. The opacity is not incidental; it is structural. No other developed nation tolerates it.

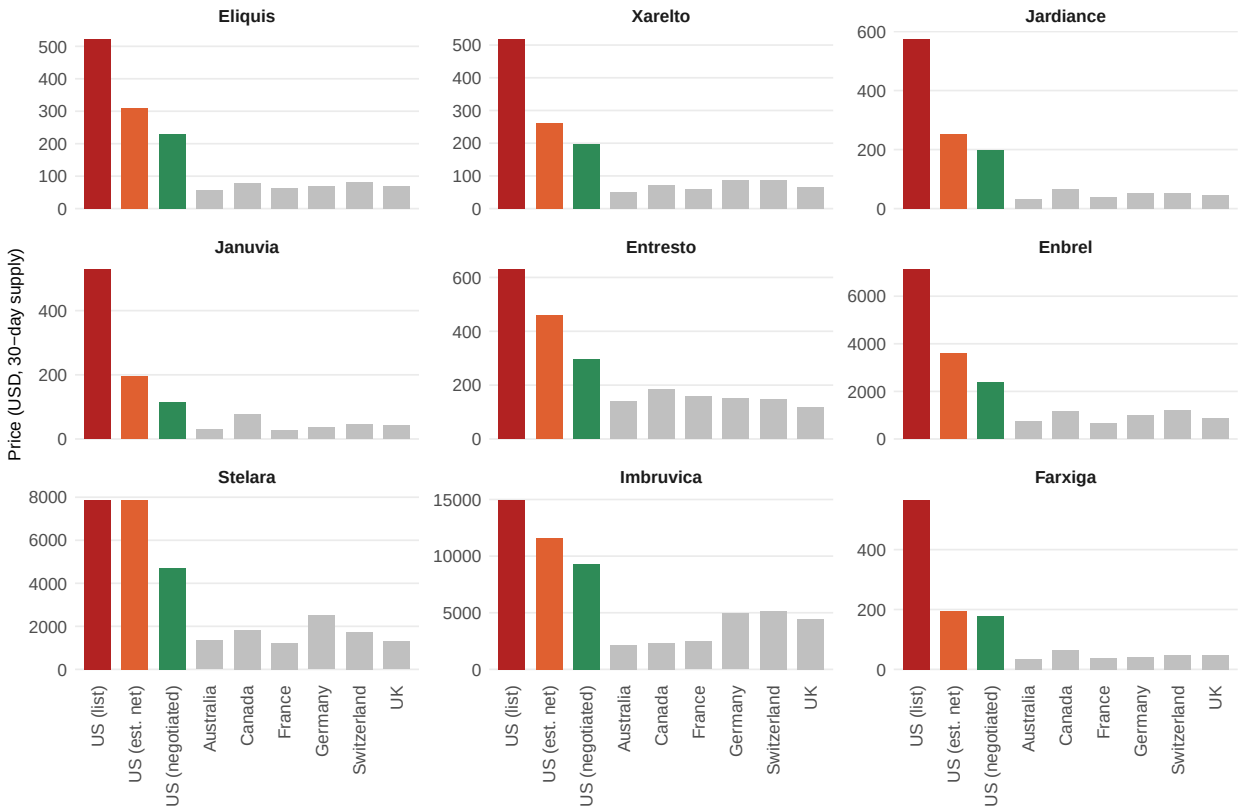

Figure 2: Drug prices by country.

Notes: Dark red is the US list price (paid by the uninsured). Orange is the estimated net price after rebates and discounts, derived from SSR Health data and SEC filings.[3] Green is the Medicare negotiated price under the Inflation Reduction Act (effective 2026). Gray bars are other developed countries. All nine drugs are among the first ten selected by CMS for Medicare negotiation based on program spending; the tenth (insulin aspart) is excluded because international prices are reported per unit rather than per 30-day supply, making direct comparison imprecise. Each panel uses its own vertical scale. Exact net prices are not publicly disclosed; the opacity of US drug pricing is itself part of the problem this proposal addresses. Full per-drug figures and sources are available on the companion site.

Why these reforms work together

Two forces from industrial organization determine an insurer's ability to bring down healthcare prices. The first is the insurer's size: the larger the insurer, the more leverage it has, because losing the insurer's volume is more painful for the provider. The second is the availability of alternative insurers: when a provider has many other insurers to turn to, the threat of walking away is credible, and the insurer's leverage is blunted. The two forces work in opposition. A large insurer surrounded by many competing insurers has weaker leverage than a smaller insurer that is the only game in town. Maximum leverage requires both: a single large insurer with no meaningful alternatives for providers. The three reforms below are designed around this logic. Consolidated negotiation makes the government a single, large insurer. Bloc-wide pricing eliminates the alternative insurers that providers could otherwise turn to for higher rates. A central price lookup system ensures the prices that emerge from negotiation are honored, not undercut by the secret arrangements that historically diluted

government leverage.

Reform 1: Consolidated government negotiation

The federal government does not negotiate healthcare prices as a single insurer. It fragments its purchasing power across Medicare, Medicaid, and at least nine other programs, each with its own formulary, fee schedule, rules, and leverage. For prescription drugs alone, these programs account for 51% of US spending, yet they compete against one another instead of bargaining as one.[4] The government pays a similarly large share of hospital and physician bills, and those payments are just as fragmented. Consolidating these programs into a single negotiating Bloc, a unified entity that bargains on behalf of all federal healthcare programs, would use leverage the government already has but wastes. Every other developed nation does exactly this, and pays far less.[5]

When the government has the power to improve healthcare, it has a duty to use it. This is incontrovertible. Walmart negotiates with its suppliers. The Department of Defense negotiates with its contractors. The VA already negotiates drug prices and pays roughly half what Medicare Part D pays for the same medications.[6] For most of its history, Medicare was statutorily prohibited from negotiating drug prices at all, an arbitrary and indefensible restriction with no policy rationale, found nowhere else in the federal government or in the developed world. The Inflation Reduction Act of 2022 began to reverse this, authorizing Medicare to negotiate prices for a small number of high-expenditure drugs. The government already possesses the leverage needed to negotiate the price of all drugs at once. Confining that effort to ten drugs squanders the leverage, defies any policy rationale, and wastes taxpayer money.

An average private insurer in 2022 paid 2.5 times the Medicare rate for hospital services.[7] This reflects a leverage gap: providers extract higher prices from private insurers, who lack Medicare's size and leverage. Under the Bloc, that gap collapses. The price discrimination disappears and substantial cost savings follow. Usually, the highest healthcare prices are paid to hospitals in highly concentrated markets where a single hospital chain controls the majority of an area.[8] The creation of the Bloc is anticipated to generate the largest cost savings in these markets.

For privately insured patients, the effect is a reduction in the inflated commercial rates they currently pay. Under the Bloc, the commercial premium that providers extract today collapses to the rate the Bloc negotiates. Premiums should fall, because the prices underlying those premiums fall.

Reform 2: Bloc-wide pricing as a condition of market access

Any provider, whether a pharmacy, hospital, or physician, that contracts with the Bloc must charge all payers the same price for the same service. Commercial insurers, government programs, and uninsured individuals pay the same rate. The negotiated price is locked in: insurers cannot negotiate any further discounts on the side. Any provider that refuses loses its contract with the Bloc, and with it, access to the majority of the market.

This proposal does not make all insurance plans identical. It standardizes the price, not the coverage. Once the price of a service is fixed, insurers compete on what fraction of that price they cover and what fraction the patient pays out of pocket. Generous plans cover most of the uniform price and leave the patient with a small copay. Cheaper plans may expose patients to a higher copay. Both plans pay the same price to the provider. What differs is how the cost is split between the insurer and the patient. The market for insurance plans survives intact. What disappears is the market for secret prices.

For pharmacies, the rebate ecosystem ceases to exist. There are no rebates to capture, no spread pricing to exploit, and no opaque price differentials to arbitrage.

For insurers, narrow networks lose their purpose. Today they exist because insurers negotiate lower rates from providers in exchange for steering patient volume. When every provider charges the same price, there is no price advantage to restricting network size.

Reform 3: A central price lookup system

Reforms 1 and 2 produce one negotiated price per provider per service. Reform 3 makes that price visible. The Bloc operates a single, public price lookup system. When a provider contracts with the Bloc, the negotiated prices for every covered service are transferred from the contract directly into the system by Bloc officials. The provider does not file, post, or upload anything. The data is already in the Bloc's hands; it simply moves from the contract to the database.

The lookup system is open to anyone, free, and built for comparison. A patient who needs an ENT visit can see the price at every provider in their area. A patient considering a hip replacement can compare every hospital within a chosen radius. A parent who needs an EpiPen for their child can see the price at every nearby pharmacy in real time. No registration or identity verification is required.

Enforcement follows directly. Every patient charged more than the listed price has the receipts to file a complaint, and the Bloc has the matching contract on file. The fine for

charging above the listed price is large enough to make noncompliance more expensive than compliance. Existing transparency rules, such as the Hospital Price Transparency Rule and the Transparency in Coverage Rule, have failed precisely because they delegated posting to thousands of providers and imposed symbolic penalties for noncompliance. Hospitals that ignore those rules face fines as low as $300 per day, a trivial sum for a system billing millions.[9] A central lookup system avoids both failures: the data is held by one entity, and the penalty for charging above it is substantial enough to deter noncompliance.

Today, an uninsured patient walking into a hospital is billed the chargemaster rate, which can be ten times the Medicare rate.[9] At the pharmacy they pay the undiscounted list price, which for insulin can be thirteen times what it cost at launch.[10] At the doctor's office they pay whatever the office elects to charge. Under this proposal, they pay no more than insured patients, and they can see the price in advance.

Online appendix. A set of frequently asked questions covering price-fixing, central planning, generic pricing, provider opt-outs, rural hospitals, fiscal impact, and related objections is maintained on the companion site. Comments, criticisms, and suggestions are welcome through the contact form there.

Disclosure on the use of AI. I used AI tools throughout the preparation of this manuscript to refine arguments, collect and verify data, produce figures and tables, build the companion website, and polish the prose. The ideas, intellectual contributions, and editorial judgments are mine, and I take full responsibility for the content.

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